

Charged in Theory, Waived in Practice

Auditing a Salon Booking App’s No-Show Fee Against Front-Desk Overrides

Ronja Oyelaran · Anneke Tolan — School of Emergent Priorities

Introduction

A salon booking app’s no-show fee promises automatic, uniform enforcement. Salons keep charging it selectively. What decides who actually pays?

Research questions

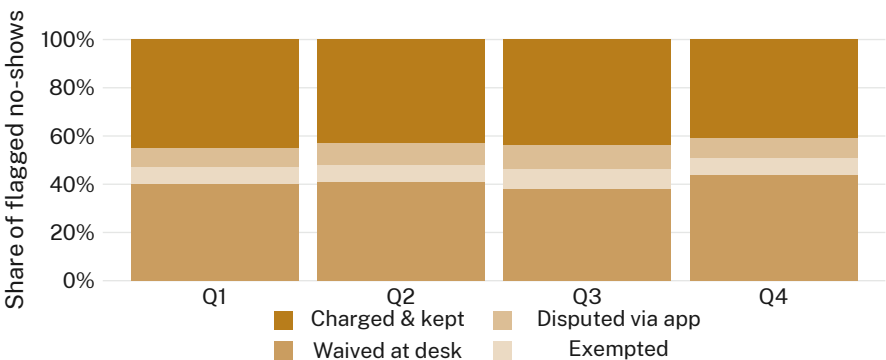
- How often is a flagged no-show fee charged versus waived?
- Who grants a waiver, and on what stated grounds?
- Does the app’s own dispute log capture what happens at the desk?

Approach

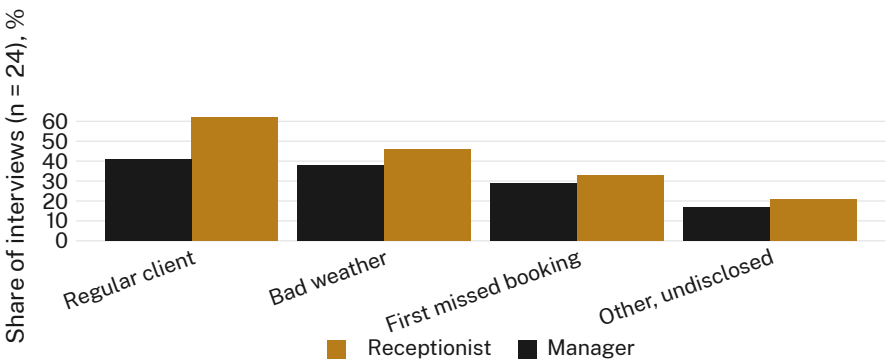
- 46 salons · booking-app fee logs · 9 months
- 24 semi-structured receptionist/manager interviews, thematic coding
- App’s dispute-resolution log cross-checked against interview accounts

Results

Staff waived a flagged fee in roughly two in five cases every quarter, a share unmoved by the app’s escalating reminder cadence. The dispute log captured only a fraction of those waivers.



Across 46 salons and four quarters, staff waived a flagged no-show fee at the desk in 38–44% of cases each quarter; the app’s own dispute log recorded only 6% of those waivers.



Receptionists cite a regular client, bad weather, or a first missed booking more often than managers do (n = 24 interviews) — grounds the app’s dispute-resolution log has no field for.

Implications & takeaways

The fee reads as automatic. Enforcement stays a front-desk judgement call, guided by criteria the app has no field for — a regular client, bad weather, a first missed booking, an awkward conversation nobody wants to have twice. The waiver, not the fee schedule, is where the salon’s actual no-show policy lives, and it lives in nobody’s records but the receptionist’s memory. Next: testing whether adding a waiver-reason field changes how often one is granted, or just changes what staff write down.

References

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We thank the reception staff of the audited salons. De-identified booking records only; no client names retained.